



JAMAICA CONSTABULARY FORCE

Planning, Research and Development Branch Guide for the Exchange of Correspondence

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1.0 Introduction

The Jamaica Constabulary Force (JCF) has placed increased emphasis on ‘*Improving Communication & Public Engagement*’ through among other things, transformation of systems and processes geared to: i) better understanding the needs and expectations of stakeholders; ii) strengthening stakeholder engagement thus building relationships; and iii) increasing citizens’ voices and choices in maintaining a robust citizen safety and security ecosystem.

One of the most popular ways of engaging with stakeholders is through the exchange of correspondence which is defined as the sharing of information by letter, email or both between/among parties dealing with related concerns. This document provides a summary guide for the exchange of correspondence in the JCF.

2.0 Guidelines

The following guidelines are published for reference when engaging with stakeholders through the exchange of correspondence:

2.1 Standardization of letter/email correspondence:

Each letter should contain:

2.1.1 Contact information - includes the name of the division, station and its address;

2.1.2 Salutation - this is the opening, usually beginning with “dear” followed by the name/title of the person whom the letter is addressed to usually place at the top left section. With email, however the contact information is placed at the bottom left below the signature;

2.1.3 The body - may contain several paragraphs and begins with an introduction and the reason for writing;

2.1.4 Closing - a letter is closed with a term such as ‘Regards’ or ‘Sincerely’ followed by a comma, usually place at the bottom left section; and

2.1.5 Signature - the author’s signature followed by job title. With email correspondence, contact information is also place below.

2.2 When communicating with stakeholders both internal and external, the above information must be contained within letters/emails and clearly outlined throughout. Please note also, that the letters should be single spaced with double spacing employed between paragraphs and each section.

2.3 Email correspondence must be sent via JCF email unless special provision is granted.

3.0 Replying to emails with more than one recipient

3.1 Often, emails are sent to multiple recipients some of whom do not need to privy to the reply of others. To know whether to ‘reply’ or ‘reply to all’ answer the following questions:

3.1.1 Is the email addressed to me? If yes, there is no need to reply to all;

3.1.2 Does more than one person need to know the email was responded to? If yes, answer the next question

3.1.3 Does the email affect more than half the people on the chain? Also yes? Then ‘reply to all’

3.1.4 Do the others need to remain on the chain? No? ‘reply’ will suffice.

4.0 Ways in which information is exchanged

Information is primarily shared in three different ways: on request, spontaneously, or automatic/routinely. Detailed further:

4.1 The exchange of information on request:

4.1.1 This requires an agent of the Force or its auxiliaries to respond to questions or statements outlined in an official correspondence from either an internal or external customer. For example, responding to a Notice from IPROB about an official complaint made against a member during the course of a duty.

Treatment:

- i. Bring the matter to the attention of your immediate supervisor;
- ii. Respond to the request in writing by the deadline required by the sender;
- iii. Be guided by our responsibility to the public and the organization.

4.2 Spontaneous information exchange:

4.2.1 This is the transmission of information to a third party without a request being prompted or requested by the receiving party if, the sender of the information perceive that the information to be sent is of importance to the third party. For example, writing to inform the Child Protection and Family Services Agency about a child you have observed that is in need of care and protection.

4.3 Automatic exchange of information:

4.3.1 Refers to the routine and systematic sharing of information between/among parties. Many a times, a Memorandum of understanding is in place which governs this. Nonetheless, when this is done, it helps to improve transparency and facilitates greater stakeholder engagement. This is best demonstrated with the publication of the Force Orders:

- i. There is no request for the document;
- ii. It is published routinely every Friday; and
- iii. The relevant agency of the Force with this responsibility ensures that the information is disseminated to all relevant parties and on a timely basis.

4.4 Security and confidentiality of information exchanged

4.4.1 As law enforcement practitioners, oftentimes we will be engaged in the sharing of information but internally and with external stakeholders. Whilst, exchange of information builds relationships with these stakeholders, one has to be mindful of the content that is being disseminated, with whom it is shared, and the security of said information disclosed.

4.4.2 Information can be categorized as either classified or unclassified where classified data requires high confidentiality and unclassified information has fewer restrictions, however there may still be information within an unclassified correspondence that may be sensitive and requires care in handling and dissemination.

5.0 Treating with Classified and Sensitive Unclassified Information:

5.1.1 Dissemination: All correspondence deemed as classified or which may contain sensitive unclassified data, MUST be sent via a secure channel - if by letter, the envelope must be sealed and labelled with the word 'CONFIDENTIAL' displayed conspicuously on the front; if sending by email, the JCF's secure email server must be used and the document

bearing a watermark with the words 'CONFIDENTIAL'. The JCF's Personal Use of Social Media and Corporate Media Policies must be adhered to.

- 5.1.2 Receipt:** All official correspondence received by an agent of the Force must be treated confidentially and all attempts made to safeguard the information unless directed otherwise by appropriate management.

6.0 Timeline for response

- 6.1** As outline by the JCF Electronic Mail Policy first published in Force Orders #3641 dated March 16, 2017, an email is deemed read after two (2) days or upon acknowledgement by the recipient whichever is earlier.

- 6.2** Also, the said policy instructs employees to check their email at least once per day. In light of the above, all members are required to respond to internal correspondences within forty-eight hours of receipt/acknowledgement or where otherwise directed.

7.0 Related Records and Forms

- 7.1** JCF Electronic Mail Policy
7.2 JCF Personal Use of Social Media Policy
7.3 JCF Corporate Media Policy